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John Pizzarelli
Part 2

In the ensuing 23 years since John's first interview, he has fashioned a robust career with his prowess as a jazz guitarist and swinging vocalist. John also hosts the NPR show Radio Deluxe with his wife, Jessica Molasky.

John was interviewed via Zoom on October 18, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and this is a long-delayed Part 2 interview with John Pizzarelli. Do you know that it was twenty — I can't do the math —

JP: Was it '96?

MR: No it was more like, I think it was 2000. And we were in New York and we had a wonderful session and I just would like to say, and I hope you agree with me that both you and I haven't aged a day, don't you think?

JP: I don't know — we look great.

MR: Well that's a good place to start. I had the pleasure with about 200 plus other people of having you to Hamilton a couple of weeks ago and it was a marvelous concert. There was a couple of things I wanted to ask you about it. You have a terrific piano player with Isaiah Thompson, and there was a few moments throughout the night, he was sitting to your left, and you would lean over while you were playing and say something to him. And the person that was sitting next to me and I were sort of wondering, well what are they talking about? Going out for pizza afterwards or something? Can you give us an inside story of what those little exchanges are for?

JP: Well during the song it might be to — I might say like sometimes I say, "Here we go" and it means we're finishing the song. Like we'll be playing a tag [scats] "Here we go" [scats] and everybody knows. Sometimes I just say stupid things to him to make him laugh. So like between songs. Or I'll just say we're going to do this next and, you know and I'll say like, "I almost did okay on that one" you know or something. Like trying to keep it a little lighter. But during the song sometimes I'll yell out a new key, and the funny thing was, and two piano players, actually Isaiah and Tadataka Unno, a Japanese piano player, I always — if I want to call D flat as a key I say "five." It's an old Bucky thing, five flats is D flat. And it seems to me that I don't do it for any other keys but D flat. I always say five. I won't say four, A flat, is the A flat. But for D flat it's always five. It's been a Bucky thing forever. So one time at the very beginning of Isaiah's time with us I turned around and said, "Let's do 'Body and Soul' in five." And Isaiah turned to

same thing, I think Tadataka said the same thing, he says, "You only say 'five' for D flat." He goes, "It's like one of those weird things." Because we trade fours I'll say "fours." But "five" is D flat. It's one of those little communication things. When I was with Bucky it was always eyebrows were the communicator. So when you're playing, if you're playing this way and you look over and you saw him go like that it meant he was going to look at you, or in that case me, and I knew something — here there's a change that's coming and the eyebrows always signaled that.

MR: I just, that's so interesting. And I've seen it. I've probably done it myself, but the look, like you get this look and with guitar players, you know there's the hand, and the look should tell you what this is going to be. And you go, "Well that could be lot of things."

JP: Yeah. But since we've been playing together they know that that means they know what the section is. It's like with Bucky I knew when his eyebrows went up, okay he's going to either turn it over to me or here comes the shout chorus or something of that, that was the message. I know that there's a couple of things, somebody wrote the other day, it was Ray Brown's birthday and somebody wrote — oh George Fludas the drummer put up a thing that was Ray, George Fludas and Larry Fuller at the piano and Fludas had gone to his, there's a certain cymbal, the China cymbal. And he's playing away on it and the signal from Ray was, "Garbage." 'Cause he said it was a garbage lid. That cymbal. So he'd say, "Go garbage" something, just say "garbage" and he knew that's the cymbal that Ray wanted.

MR: Was there such a thing in a jazz group as like five sharps, or jazz guys don't play in five sharps, but rock guys do.

JP: Right. Five flats.

MR: What are you nuts? Five sharps? We don't do that. Well you've always had a gift of gab and that's a compliment. And I've wondered, Bucky was not very verbose. He let his music speak. Did the early rock & roll experience you had help you get comfortable on stage interacting with the audience?

JP: No you know actually in New Jersey I worked with a guy named Grover Kemble. And Grover was a — still is, is like a Jersey presence. He was a guy who'd go out and play the guitar and he would constantly egg the band on, I mean egg the audience on. And it was always so interesting. I'm just going to turn that off there so we don't get anymore dings.

MR: I'm going to turn off something here myself, hold on.

JP: Okay.

MR: We'll get rid of that, the heat fan came on.

JP: But I think it's actually a number of things. I mean when I was a kid I loved comedy records. I had Bill Cosby's "Why is There Air?" I don't know how that record got in the

four — three of his records. And I liked to watch Johnny Carson and I liked the timing of a story, of a joke. And I always point to, I don't know if I mentioned this the first time or not, there were three concerts in '85 — March 14th of '85 Sinatra was at the Brendan Byrne arena in New Jersey. And then that summer Springsteen was at the big stadium, and previously about a year or two earlier, probably '83 like the day after Christmas Billy Joel was at Brendan Byrne arena also. And I loved the way it was not about the music. The music was unbelievable, but it was the way the presentation. The Billy Joel part of it was he played three songs. The third song was the first big hit. He played "Allentown," something, and then "My Life." Woo. And then he spoke. And then spoke and then went to something. And Billy Joel's show was very — there was a lot going on and he would run up to one area and he was conscious of the fact that the piano was a static thing. Now the piano spins. But he had another piano somewhere else. And it was really well done. Sinatra just had control of the entire arena. He was right in the middle. And that particular night he was absolutely flawless. There's a record of it now. And I was taken by just the way that he presented the songs. I mean it was just, he knew exactly how that all fell together and what he was doing. And Springsteen, for 76,000 people — and I didn't know half the material. If I knew half it was a lot. But it was a big deal. It was the "Born in the U.S.A." tour and I was watching this guy and I'm going how does this guy stand with an acoustic guitar — and then I was walking on the Boardwalk in Asbury Park and this was going on and that. And everybody's leaning in. 76,000 people and I thought that's a gift. And what I do, what I want to do, based on those three things was I have to be able to present this music to the non-music-fan. Because everybody — the music fans are all going to know what it is. They're going to know this and that. But they're going to bring somebody with them. I always say there's the John Pizzarelli fan and the person they brought with them. And that's the person who I've got to say the reason we're doing this — or this is an "Oklahoma" suite and here's what's going to happen, and this song came from here. Sometimes it's too much. Like you know but I'm conscious of the beginning, the middle and the end of the story. I mean to me that's the, you know, I still like the damn Zoot Sims "Something's Gotta Give" story has no anything to it but I like to tell the story 'cause it means a lot to me and because Bucky had told me the story. And I'll tell you the story, well I'm going to tell you real quickly again. So Bucky had said so you know Zoot plays and then Zoot says, and Benny says, "Do an encore" and Zoot says, "I'll do 'It Had to be You' and Benny goes, "great idea." And he goes to the piano player, "It Had to be You" [scats] and Zoot stands there. And at the end Zoot looks at — and he's got his hand on his hip and he sort of scratches his head, 'cause now there's a video of it and I see the whole thing happen and Zoot leans in and says "You just played my

road — and those tours were like six weeks because we have the itinerary on our wall in the house of my mother's mother and father stayed with us and they went all over the place. That's 1972. And so the fact that there's a film of that is so exciting, and to watch them joking around and Benny goes, "Well play another one" and Zoot says, "No, I'm not going to play another one." And it's really — it was sort of inside baseball you know but it was so — it's just wonderful to see that there was some joy out there.

MR: Speaking of inside joyful stories I may be one of the few people who know, because of you, that Slam Stewart liked to have Ovaltine and cookies before he went to bed and Zoot called them "knock-out drops."

JP: You know the thing that was interesting about that is I got the assignment, you know, so Bucky came home from Marty's with Slam and Bucky would go to bed and I would say, and there was Ovaltine and so Slam loved to sit there and there was a table in our kitchen that had a little TV and I would sort of sit there and watch him have cookies and Ovaltine and he would always take a sip and he'd go, "knock out drops, ha-ha-ha-ha." And he would just say that. And you know the interesting thing about that was I had no interest in — not interest — I was sort of ignorant of the fact of who I was sitting with. I knew he was just a great bass player. I had no — I think it made it better as opposed to me going, "Hey, while you're having that Ovaltine and trying to relax, tell me about Art Tatum." You know it was the only thing he told me about once I asked him about Nat Cole, when I finally had the chance I said, "So what was Nat Cole like?" And he said, "Well he was a really good piano player at the jam sessions and then one day he started singing." And that was the story. Well I'm glad I — you know.

MR: I have here an article from the *New York Times* it's entitled — it's a review — "A Family Reunion with a Smile" John Pizzarelli at the Regency. And I wanted to read just a short bit from it. This is a fellow named Steven Holden. He said, "For all the whimsy he weaves into his music, the jokes and references never devolve into comic shtick but embody his view of music-making as intellectual and aesthetic play.

JP: That's when they used to be able to write in the *New York Times*.

MR: Yeah.

JP: Well you know I think that's — you know I think I still border on the shtick but I've gotten a little better at it, at the important times anyway. I mean I like the idea of, you know we used to joke with Bucky about, you know could you at least tell us what the next song is? Could we have a clue? Will you let us in? You know when he would do solo concerts when I was between ten and fifteen. But then when he worked with John Bunch and Jay Leonhart, they would let — Bucky would talk for a while and then he'd say, "John Bunch" and John would say, "Here's what we're going to do next." You know

that stemmed out. And I think the other part was I like to tell little stories about the things that connected the dots a little bit.

MR: Yeah it doesn't get pedantic which I like because sometimes you feel oh they're trying to teach you something now and you should know this.

JP: Right.

MR: And that's a turn off. But I also just wanted to make an observation that I like the fact that you know you only have three musicians but sometimes people don't realize that taking out an instrument or two adds another texture to the whole affair, and you all did that.

JP: Yeah well it's a — that's — everything involved in the drumless trio, which we did — actually I think when I first talked to you we had drums in the group or were just starting to have more drums. Tony Tedesco played with us for years and it was really a monetary decision to go back to the drumless group because we were going to Europe and I said well we can't afford this but I can do it with a drumless group because it gives me another harmonic instrument, the piano. So piano, guitar and bass. And I'm used to working in that format. I started out like that and that's how I remember hearing my father's group. So there's something about that group that everybody's got to be involved. Nobody can sort of sit back and say, "I just played my chorus" you know, "take it." Everybody's got to keep the motion moving. You know. And that's what's exciting about that. I love that sound — you know the rhythm guitar and coming up with figures that work with the piano and those kind of shout choruses and things like that. That's one of the things. We have it in here. Speaking of — there's a thing — it's what Bucky and I, it's based on that too — no this is John Wilson in December of '85 when he says, "They come together on common ground at fast tempos when the hard-driving chorded attack that Bucky Pizzarelli has always used in these situations is picked up by his son, intensifying the rhythmic effect and enabling them to suggest a big band in full flight. The tiller-dillers or Benny Goodman's band or the trumpet shakes of Count Basie's." That's a great thing. It's one of the first reviews that Bucky and I got and I keep it in my office.

MR: Yes. And when you do that thing of the other guys drop out and it was uptempo and you're doing this [scats] and I remember thinking, "Wow, is he going to make it?" First of all it just physically seems like a thing — I wonder if you've ever been doing that and you like drop a beat or add a beat?

JP: There's been definitely times when something goes wrong and I'll even say it, you know, but the guys know where I am and they'll get back and at the end — another thing like when I turn around and I'll say, "I owe you a beat" or "I owe you a measure." So there are those moments. Not as much as they used to be but there are those things. I'm not as,

and they always land on their feet. And you know sometimes I like when that happens but if it keeps going, you know I drop my pick.

MR: Like dropping the mic I guess. Something you just said made me think of — I'm not, I haven't kept up as much as I should on current instrumental jazz releases but when I listen these days it almost seems like swinging — to swing — has become square. And nobody wants to just play the time, they all want to play with the time.

JP: Right.

MR: Do you hear that?

JP: Well you know I had this conversation with Isaiah. And I was saying you know I get lucky because I manage to find piano players who want to swing, who want to play tunes, and participate in the band like that. I've heard — I mean I've been in bands where I'm the guy who's trying to play rhythm guitar and the group is a completely different animal and the rhythm guitar is a dinosaur and you sort of just go oh, I'm fighting the wrong fight here. And so I'm amazed that I can find piano players who want to play tunes and Isaiah's like this — Isaiah actually made a point about — there was an Oscar Peterson tribute at Lincoln Center or something and he went and he said it was like nobody was there, it was sort of like — it's almost taken for granted, for Oscar Peterson especially, I've talked about it over the years is that you know the most swinging piano player, one of the swingingest piano players on the planet — one of the swingingest musicians. There's so much to learn from him and it's sort of like yeah, yeah, well he was swinging. You know they're swinging. Well I always say there are certain tunes, because "I Know That You Know," that song. D 7, G 7, C, A 7. D 7, G 7, C [scats]. You know if you're going [scats] you know we could try and play that altogether. I've been playing that song, I mean that's sort of the litmus test for me, these kinds of — I actually have, I keep it in my phone, if this is okay with you.

MR: Sure.

JP: This — I have these quotes that I like to — I call it Random Quotes. One in particular, just so you know what I keep in here, it's something Dave Frishberg said. He said, "Jazz musicians were hip. They were funny, they were sensitive, they were clannish, and they seemed to have the best girlfriends." That's something Dave Frishberg — just so you know what I have in here. But I have this quote from Joshua Redman. And I read it to Isaiah one night and he was like, "Can you send that to me?" And so he said, "I still think one of the hardest things to do is to get up there and just play a medium tempo swinging blues. Just to swing with focus, with power, and with relaxation. That's an incredibly difficult thing to do. There may be some musicians who, to be quite honest, can't do it and don't want to spend the time learning how to do it, so they justify that by saying

aren't playing music that is technically swing music, the ones that are good have dealt with that and have that as a basis in what they do. And if they want up on the bandstand on a jam session and the band was playing 'C Jam Blues' they could get up there and take a smoking solo on that." And I think that's the best explanation. You know so you have the knowledge of it at least. It's not an excuse to say, "Oh I'm not going to do that." I hope that made some sense.

MR: It did, indeed. Let me ask you about — I got this thought in my head sort of full circle that when you were young you were playing Beatles music and then X number of years later you're playing with Paul McCartney. Pretty cool.

JP: It is. It was actually pretty cool for Bucky too, which is the funny part. He was so excited. Because I got the call first and I could do literally one day. I flew in from Georgia, did the gig, flew out the next day to a gig in Clarksville, Tennessee and they still had another day. So somewhere before the date they called me and said, "Do you think your father would do the date?" I said, "He's in the book, I said, "he'll go anywhere." So he got there. I was there. I got there at 10 AM. Me and Al Schmidt were the first guys in the studio. And somewhere around like noon Bucky walked in. He was — we had been staying across the street from Capitol. And but I remember we were just all — Paul McCartney for crying out loud. And that was the big — I tell the story of shaking Paul's hand, being introduced by Tommy LiPuma to Paul McCartney and Paul said, "You made a Beatles CD." And I was like, "What!?" He goes, "Well yeah, you sent it to me, you dropped it off." And I was like, "Yeah but that was a while ago." But he was — so I remember when I was in London and I had a Beatles CD and I dropped it at the office. And it was a very wonderful experience. And he would tell — every once in a while I remember we were finishing up the day's stuff and I said to him, "When you guys finished a Beatle day, did you get an acetate? You didn't have cassettes." You know, "You might want to go home and listen to something." You know? Like you always say, "Oh can you give me a — " now it's can you burn me a CD of what we did today so I can take it home." And I said to Paul, "What did you do?" He goes, "Oh we never got it." He said, "We were just the rotten kids so nobody — they were like, oh yeah — you never did it. But there was a guy upstairs in London at the studio — I guess at Apple or wherever they were recording and his name was "Harry the Cutter" or he called him "Harry the Cut-ter" and he was the guy who could cut acetates for them. And so he said at the beginning it was sort of like Harry was like, "You guys are done, go home." And then he said we had a couple of hit records and they were like, I remember Paul going he was like, "Um, tell Harry the Cut-ter we'd like a little something to take home you know." And because we were sort of like starting to be something. It was just remarkable —

lot of fun because you know we did "The Christmas Song" for another record at the same date, "Chestnuts roasting on an open fire" and she was trying to play the intro and she was under the gun 'cause she was the director. And she'd be like thinking about everything that's going on. So she was playing and then she finally looked over at me and she goes, "You play the intro." And I was like okay. And that was like, that's something we'd talk about, you know, it was Bucky Pizzarelli 101 because every class that I went to Bucky would say, "Can you play a four bar intro? Can you play an eight bar intro?" So when they point to you and they say, "Give me four bars up front." Or "Give me eight bars." Can you do that? You know and he goes you're not playing "Cherokee" he goes, "You've got to play four bars for a singer" and you know that is what it was. There's, you know, Paul McCartney going, "Okay two, three" and you go [scats]. It was really like — that's the fun of the whole thing was accompanying him, playing an intro for him, thinking of all the Bucky Pizzarelli lessons on those dates.

MR: That's not a good feeling if you're supposed to set up the singer and it comes for their entrance and they can't —

JP: Right, no. You've got to know where you're going to start. And you know there was, I mean I played years ago with Richard Davis, Carl Allen, Buddy Montgomery and myself and Ben Sidran for Ricky Lee Jones. And she was making a demo which would become a partial record of standards. And I remember she wanted to do "Embraceable You" and I played the first chord [scats] and she went [sings] "Embrace me." And I went [scats] and she said, "What's your hurry?" I was like what am I supposed to do? So it was a complete different learning experience. I was like okay I've got to figure out what the hell I'm going to — but she wanted everything very slow and you'd go oh boy.

MR: Slow is hard.

JP: Slow is very hard.

MR: You also mentioned — it's time to mention working with James Taylor and you spoke about his distinctive guitar playing which I found to be very interesting.

JP: Well we did — the first part was Russ Titelman called me to play, do a date for him in August of 2001. And it was down at Clinton. And he had a song called "Mean Old Man." And I was in the booth with my guitar and James came into the thing and he was showing me the chords. They had sort of a nutty chord sheet and James came in and he went — and he always whistles like, playing all the chords. And I'm going this is James Taylor sitting in front of me. And I could see Russ Titelman on the other side, outside the booth looking at me like, "Don't start crying or anything, just pay attention. Can you please do that much?" And so we did the thing and I remember I actually played the verse with him on that. [sings] On my own [scats] I play the finger and then, just to blow my own horn

Goldings played piano and Steve Gadd was the drummer. And I remember when I played the track for Bucky, I said, "Hey listen to this." So he heard the thing and then the second he heard [sings] the first chunk he said, "Who's the rhythm player?" I said, "Thank you very much." I said, I passed the test. So James said something to me like, "Well you've got to show me how you do that rhythm thing, that's really great." I mean he really liked the rhythm guitar. And I said to him, "Well you can show me that finger picking thing and we'll be even" you know. So when he — we had to do not "I'll be Home for Christmas," the other one. "Have Yourself a Merry Little Christmas." Same date. But he had a lead sheet of the verse. [sings] Christmas future is far away/Christmas past is past/Christmas present is here to stay. And so there was the thing and I did a Bucky Pizzarelli thing. And I looked at the lead sheet and I said it says there's an A chord, whatever the hell it was, the third was in the bass. Because Bucky would always say, "Look at the lead sheet and see where the bass notes are, it's going to show you all your voice leading is going to be right there." So if you just played A – E – A – E — it wasn't A – E, it was a chromatic movement down [scats] and I could see the whole thing and I was so proud of myself because I was like — I finally — it was another moment, another Bucky Pizzarelli moment. And so James called me, so it only took him twenty-some-odd years before — no, about seventeen years later he texted me and said, "I want to do a record of standards and you da man" it said. And he just wanted me to come in, and I think the original idea was for me to be there and make sure harmonically he was in the right ballpark. And then, because the first thing he did was "Old Man River." He had some really nice things on that. And I was like, "Well there's a nice little chord you could play here," and he'd go, "okay." And I was in the booth and then after that he said, "well let's" — we had played together "My Blue Heaven" just on a gig that we did shortly after the record in '01. And I said, "Let's play 'My Blue Heaven.'" And he said — we started to play it, the two guitars together, I was sort of finger picking and he was finger picking but I was sort of coming up with different inversions around what he was doing. And I had the bass note on the seven string classical that I had. And then he was sort of like, "Well that's pretty good." He goes, "You want to put rhythm on that now?" And I said sure. So they run it back and I had an L 7 and I was — I played the rhythm on it and he was like, "Yeah." So then we had a format when we'd do "Pennies From Heaven" he would come up with his thing, and he always wanted to change the chords on the second time around so we would come up with the different set of — this was like over — each tune would be like six hours. But then at the end he'd go, "Hey, put the rhythm on now." He'd get all excited, "Get the rhythm." And I'd get the rhythm out. So he just had a — and he just James Taylorized everything. He made it all his own thing. Paul was more

sing like Little Richard or Elvis when I sing rock & roll. But here I am singing standards. I don't know who to sing like. And it was really cool. So with James Taylor he knew it was going to be James Taylorized. He just wanted to make sure it was within — you know he really had a — he was really smart. They both were smart, I mean they are both geniuses in their own little way.

MR: Would James Taylor ever go five flats to you?

JP: No, no. I never got five flats. But you know what he loved is that he loved the capo. He liked to like tune the guitar down a whole step and still put the capo on and play like in the key that it would have been anyway without the capo. He had all these kinds of ideas about how the guitar resonated even if it was — you know so the capo meant a lot to him. He was like, "Don't you want to use the capo?" I said, "I don't have to." I said, you know like Bucky used to say, he did a date once for Carly Simon. And he worked this whole thing out on "I've Got a Crush on You." And it was in F. And then the guy said, "Well that's all right, but can you do it in G flat" which would be — and Bucky said, "Sure," he goes, "it's only an inch away. Just move it up."

MR: Did Bucky or John Pizzarelli ever use a capo on a date?

JP: I did on the James Taylor. He put one on the guitar. "All right" I'll say, "whatever you like." You know. But Bucky — no I don't think he did. I saw a banjo player do it on a commercial date we were at.

MR: Along those lines, if there was such a thing as a jazz police and they came to your house with a search warrant, would they find any Real Books in your house?

JP: No. You know what they would find? They would find Cole Porter, I've got a whole thing over here, there's Johnny Mercer, Sammy Cahn, Jerome Kern. We had the Real Book, the old school Real Book. Bucky had it in a binder. He used to — I think it was either me or him would say what you should do is you start at the beginning — it's usually "Alone Together" is the first one, you know A. Or "A Child is Born." You learn the first one and you rip it out. You learn it. You learn the next one, you rip it out. And at the end you've got a nice binder. So, and as I've said before, I learned from Bucky Pizzarelli pounding the melody out — he just wanted to hear chords. I'd say, "Are you going to write it out?" He goes, "No." He'd just go [hums] and he'd sort of look at me.

MR: The look.

JP: Chord? You know chord? I think I told that story, you know.

MR: Yeah you said it was the hardest thing and the most valuable thing, or something like that.

JP: You know I think he did it that way because he saw Joe Mooney do it that way. Joe Mooney was the blind accordion player from Paterson and he would go watch their

would go, "Here's what you're going to play" [scats] and he'd go to the guitar player, "here's what you're going to play" and you had to hear it and play it. It wasn't like Joe was writing out charts for the band. This was here now let's all try it together. And that's when we learned tunes he would just start to play it and I'd go like that.

MR: Much better for memorizing too.

JP: Yeah. It was good.

MR: I'm going to play a little name that tune with you. Are you ready?

JP: Okay.

MR: All right. I'm going to start out with something easy. You just get two bars. [scats]

JP: "C Jam Blues."

MR: Okay. So you can move on to the next round here but you only get two bars in this one because that's all I had time to write out.

JP: Okay.

MR: [scats]

JP: "Let's Dance?" No. No. Oh that's "Chicken a la Swing."

MR: Yes. Very good. Okay you get one more but I'm going to give you some clues because I don't know how well I can vocalize this one. First of all, key of G, 3/4 time, imagine accordion, clarinet and cello in the background. All right? [scats]

JP: One more time.

MR: Starts on the five. [scats]

JP: [scats] that's the part of the tune.

MR: Yeah I'm not sure I got that right, okay. That's a hint.

JP: Oh, oh, is it "DaVinci's Eyes?"

MR: It is indeed. It's a beautiful song and I just was listening to it and I loved it when the accordion came in and I got this sense of your family history and Bucky talking about the accordion and all that. And so I just wanted to say nice going, and Jessica, I don't know how this line came up to be but there's the line that it sort of waits to get to, and then "What DaVinci would do with your eyes."

JP: That's a great line. It's a great song. And what happened was it's based on well Dominick Cortese plays the accordion and he's a family friend. And he's the accordion player on, there's a song called "Where's the Orchestra" that ends the "Allentown" record, Billy Joel's record. And it's similar to that kind of thing. And I always loved that sound. And Don Sebesky wrote the arrangement for the cello and Ken Peplowski and Harry Allen and Dominick. Because Sebesky's an old — was an old accordion player. And I sort of liked the idea that was that [scats and sings] what DaVinci would do, what DaVinci would do with your eyes. Molaskey's written a lot of great lyrics and so we sneak them

MR: Well they do, at least I do.

JP: Thank you. I'll pass that along. That was one of the first songs we played on our FaceBook Thursday night show during the pandemic and everybody went crazy for "DaVinci's Eyes" the first couple of weeks we played it so we kept looking at each other and going are they hearing the right stuff?

MR: When you worked, you've been with a couple of different record labels. If you went to them and said we would like to do a CD of all original material, what would they respond?

JP: We did try to do one, for one of the labels. And it wasn't received well. And I think we were, the funny part was we were three songs off. We had a bunch of good songs and then there were a couple at the end of the list that weren't so hot. And so we literally in like a day or two came up with three songs to replace those but the die was cast as it were. But it's something that — I like sneaking them on the records as opposed to a whole record just for familiarity's sake. But there's two on the Sinatra and Jobim record, there's one called "She's So Sensitive" and "Canto Casual" just a simple tune. And those got well reviewed. So we're just slowly working our way up to it. I wouldn't mind doing it myself. It's got to be — we've got to really — we have a couple of good ones in the pipeline.

MR: How is the technology of the day affecting selling your music? You made a crack about you had the "Stage & Screen" CD with you at the concert and you found a funny way to put it, you said, "Yeah if you buy the CD next time I come back I'll sell you a CD player."

JP: Yeah. I think the thing, my goal, which will never happen but my feeling is I don't understand why we give all of our music to Spotify. Because that is — I mean there's this idea that our music is free and there's no blood, sweat or tears involved in it and money spent on it. I mean there's a lot of money that's spent on making a record. It costs just at the cheapest — at the cheapest it's five thousand dollars I think. I mean to make a good record. And that's pulling a lot of strings, if you'll pardon the expression, that's no pun intended. But I mean a really good record, with horns and everything, you can make, if you're lucky enough for fifteen thousand dollars and then to twenty. And then we put it on Spotify and let everybody listen to it like, "Oh I listen on Spotify" well I haven't figured out why we do that. And I keep thinking if we just all said, "You know, we're going to take a month off and pull all of our music off of Spotify and make people buy our music. It's only nine dollars for a record, is it twelve dollars? It's nothing. It's two beers. It's one beer somewhere.

MR: Wherever you go, yeah.

JP: At the Carlyle it's half a beer. So I think, just that's the one thing I can't figure out. And you know luckily my fans like to have the record on them. I don't have one here. Oh here, "James Taylor."

MR: I have one.

JP: Yeah there you go.

MR: Hey yours looks the same as mine.

JP: Yeah.

MR: I thought it was wonderful that you had your trio on the record. And like people might say well yeah, well of course. But a lot of times people have ringers or whatever, and you have built in ringers.

JP: Yeah I mean I made a record — one of my most successful early records was "Dear Mr. Cole" with Benny Green and Christian McBride. And we never worked together. And we had a great time making the record but I really have to say I'm really pleased that we were able to have the group and bring the group out, especially with Isaiah's success so early, winning the American Pianist Award and being so popular at the moment and things like that. But he has expressed to me that he likes — wants to stay in the band as long as he can, enjoys playing in the band, I mean and then, you know, it's a great little group. I mean I love the group. I've loved all the groups up until this point, you know I mean so it's nice to make a — the goal is to try and make records that we can promote like that.

MR: That's what you said pretty much 23 years ago when we met. I had asked you the question what are your goals in, I said, 15 years. But you said that, that you wanted to keep doing what you're doing, do it better, be more organized, make some better bread.

JP: So I think the organization part, that part changed my life. I did finally get a stage plot that works. I got the lists of all the different shows that I can do. There's a big band show, there's a four horn show, there's orchestra shows. But the biggest part of the organization was having the charts — a readable chart — which took me forever. I was a bad chart writer and I finally, you know here I still even have this from Jessica's show the other day. But I didn't realize, I mean I used to really be — what am I going to do if so-and-so can't make the date you know. And what am I going to do. And now I've made sure — that was the biggest thing is that when you have such a really good group and then Isaiah says, "I've got to go promote my record here" I know I can send the set list and the music to somebody and get that — and not worry about it. And then also with a guy like Mike Karn who knows everybody, so you can get this guy, you can get Jeb Patton, you can get Tadataka, you know there are guys out there. That's the hardest thing, you want to find the guy who can sit down and be in the band you know.

JP: No they're just chord charts and then I'll send them the record so I said you know, "You'll see where the shout chorus is." And to me that's the funny part is like I like the guy to learn the tunes and if like when Isaiah joined the band I was like, "Okay, you learned the Nat Cole stuff, great, that's something." But when we do, I'm not a stickler for like, "Hey we're going to all do this." I like it to sort of organically happen, to say like, you know, "Be on the lookout, I may play a figure we could all play it together." You hear it, you'll play it. And that part's sort of fun. I like to just have the harmonies in the beginning, you know, know how we're going to start and finish. You know the ending might be nice.

MR: Start and end together.

JP: That's the hardest part.

MR: A few years ago my wife and I wrote a book based on these interviews and the publisher said, "Well first we want to know who's your audience?" And for some reason I got a little annoyed with the question. I mean like well jazz people. I mean have you ever had a record label say that to you? Like who's your audience? And should you do any adjustment of your song list and etcetera.

JP: Well you know I try to make, I have a record that I'm trying to finish up of songs again from '60s, '70s, and '80s. I continually have these things because and I say I just made this "Stage & Screen" record and I really feel like we finally communicated what we do. It only took me, you know 33 years to sit on the stage and go oh, "Too Close for Comfort" and that, and feel like people are getting it. You know really on a wider stage than just say jazz people. I just felt like this is something that's unique, how we're going about this, or at least we're carrying on a tradition in a really great way. And yet the people who are my age would know the songs from the '60s and '70s. We all grew up with this music and I think the other thing that's sort of interesting is when I was twenty, with Bucky, there were the jazz listeners. They were their own group. They were maybe Bucky's age. But they didn't have The Beatles. They had Count Basie and Oscar Peterson and that music, Sinatra. It was a specific group I think. And as I got older there were the people who were my age who were brought up with their parents playing those things and starting to go oh — and then you had Diana Krall and Natalie Cole and Harry Connick singing standards on the radio in the '90s and everybody going oh this was a new thing. It was like hip to know "It Had to be You" all of a sudden, to sing "Unforgettable." So I'm leaving out a completely different thing I was going to say. But so the hardest thing is thinking about can we sell records playing jazz of more recent songs and still communicate to those people who like "Too Close for Comfort" and "As Time Goes By" and those things. So that's always the challenge like I want to go okay.

They want to know what you have to say. And they have, they've followed me through the Beatle record and through "Double Exposure" and the bossa nova records and tours of those things. I think the thing is not to make it a complete show. I would still say you've still got to play something here, something there, and in the middle you can promote the new album but I think it's still like as opposed to making it an entire evening of one thing.

MR: Um hum.

JP: It's alienating.

MR: Yeah. I agree. We'll have to wrap up here so you can get — you have a gig tonight. Do you have anything that you'd like to share about Radio Deluxe, which is very deluxuous. Is that a word?

JP: Sure.

MR: You can use that in your next song, okay, I give you permission.

JP: That's pretty good. Well you know we've done the show for eighteen years I think. And it's been a great way to keep up on what everybody's doing, you know that's the one thing I really like about it is we — and unfortunately it's the bane of Spotify in that you can go onto Spotify or actually I go to iTunes and there's new releases. And I can hear just what the new releases are and find them and try to you know incorporate, you know there is a lot of great new music out there. There's a lot of great singers, male and female. And great jazz musicians. So it's fun to, I mean last week's show there was at least four new singers out there, or jazz musicians like Isaiah and Benny Benack III and Samara Joy and this girl Katie Kortum. And then the funny thing was is I was that person 33 years ago, you know I was making "All of Me" and "Naturally" and all those records that were big deals back — you know that was when it was a big deal to put out your record and all right are we on the charts, what have we done?

MR: Do you have people contacting you like boy I wish you'd play this — play my record?

JP: Sometimes people will say, you know, or you'll meet somebody and they give you a record or here and there and, or you see it on FaceBook, "I just had new album out" and you go and look at it. The material is the thing. That's what separates I think the winners from the losers and for lack of a better term is that I've heard, I remember there was a young girl made a record and one of the songs was "Second Time Around." And I was like well the first time around must have been sixth grade, you know? If you're the "Second time Around" it's lovelier the second time around so it's like think about your material. You're singing "Lush Life" already you know. And I've had people have that — not argument but that discussion. You know I didn't get around to Sinatra 'til I was in my 40s. I was trying to find this material I could sing, and so finally felt I had a little

something to offer that I could find arrangements that would work so that was always a challenge too.

MR: Just to wrap up, do you have any things, I guess musically, that aggravate you?

JP: Yeah. I mean there's one — there was a — the thing I think one thing that aggravates me, it's like when people from outside of the genre — and I don't mean musicians, but like actors or something and there's like the thing where they go, I'm going to play jazz now and everybody goes, oh it's so cool it's this famous person is playing jazz. And you go well I heard what you did and I feel like I have some sort of knowledge of what jazz is. And that's fine but there are so many other people I could be watching right now. And so I don't want to —

MR: I know who you're talking about. At least two or three people, yes.

JP: And so you know that kind of thing, but I mean the good news is is there's a lot of great music out there. There's a lot of kids who now can learn in high school and in college from real live great teachers of jazz. I mean a guy like Isaiah, they — you know Isaiah and Mike, and Mike's a product of the New School I think, too. And Isaiah out of Juilliard. And they'll sit and they'll sing choruses on these records they listen to. I make it sound like these records they listen to — but they're so immersed in it. And my thing was more Bucky Pizzarelli led me down a Bucky Pizzarelli path. There was Benny Goodman, Count Basie, and Zoot Sims was our guy. So you know I was very loyal to the circle. And then there's the Joe Mooney records and then the Nat Cole records. So but I mean I was never really outside of that circle. But I'm learning more from sitting with this 26-year-old kid who is so fantastic, going, "Have you heard this Gerald Wilson record?" Have you heard this other thing, you know here's even just Phineas Newborn records that I, you know, heard in passing. And you know going on car rides with this guy, it's like a master class. Don't give me a test. But that's the good news. So rather than think about the things that upset me, there's not that much. I'm just happy that we're out there. So it did take 33 years to sort of feel comfortable where you're at you know, so since the last time I've managed to keep doing what we're doing. We make decent money and the organization has gotten better. The fun thing is I've been able to look back at these things, these reviews and it's fun to think about all the work that — you know and you hear all the things that I learned in my 20s from Bucky and into my 30s I have all, one way or another as you've heard in the last hour it's been something that there was all that information. So the good news is I paid attention so that when I got my picture with Rosemary Clooney it was a good experience. You know, I earned the things, the places I got to be because I paid attention and that was the key. So I try to tell everybody the same things I've said today, you know that's what shaped where we've come to. And I

mentioned that Sebesky record a number of times in other interviews I was looking at today. And Sebesky was a big part of my life in the '90s and well just from the '90s all the way 'til his passing. You know somebody like Don Sebesky, you know, writing these arrangements and then you start to see how he harmonizes stuff and you go oh yeah that was cool. So when you start to write the chords out for somebody you go what would Don have done here? You know that was a gift.

MR: Yeah that "Time and Love" song, it took me a long time to realize besides using the melody from the Bach, he pretty much used the chart. He used Bach's chords and wrote that beautiful thing. It just — every time it really gets to me.

JP: And there's "Afternoon of a Faun" and "Lazy Afternoon" on that record. My manager back then, Buddy Morra in the '90s was friends with Don and he always would say to me, "You know you've got to get Don to give you that chart because Jessica could sing that thing and oh it's so good." But it's amazing to have been with all those people and all the people that they wrote for and the stories that they had to tell. So that's what you're doing.

MR: And congratulations on your career. And I appreciate the fantastic job you did at our Fallcoming event.

JP: Thank you.

MR: And I wish you continued success, John.

JP: Well we were on a gig the other night at a school, a high school. And when Isaiah came in I said, "You remember that piano at Hamilton?" And he said, "Yeah." I said, "This isn't that." So I'll leave you with that.

MR: I was sitting right in the front row with the top up. Wow man. That thing was powerful and he's a powerful player.

JP: He sure is. He loved that piano. He was still talking about it.

MR: All right. Well thanks for your time today and keep at it.

JP: You got it my friend. Thanks Monk, appreciate it.

MR: Bye-bye.